

USER HELP GUIDE

Browse • understand • submit • review • correct

A practical guide to using PKL with confidence.

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For visitors, contributors, prospective reviewers and anyone who wants to understand a PKL record.

Quick start

PKL is a public ledger for knowledge claims and the evidence, limitations, relationships and review decisions connected to them. You do not need specialist knowledge to browse the ledger or propose a claim.

I want to...	What to do
Explore PKL	Open the homepage and choose Browse the ledger.
Understand a record	Read the statement first, then status, evidence, limitations and related knowledge.
Submit a claim	Choose Submit a claim, complete the form and send it for review.
Become a reviewer	Choose Become a reviewer or visit /reviewers.
Report a problem	Record what happened and open an issue in the PKL GitHub repository.

PKL website: www.publicknowledgeledger.org

Reviewer information: www.publicknowledgeledger.org/reviewers

Project and support issues: github.com/elspilster/public-knowledge-ledger

What this guide covers

- How to navigate PKL
- How to read a knowledge record
- How to prepare and submit a useful claim
- What review means and what happens next
- How to suggest corrections or challenge a decision
- How to apply as a reviewer
- Privacy, safety, accessibility and troubleshooting

PKL is evolving. A screen or function may change before this guide is revised. The principles and user journey described here remain the reference; current availability is labelled where it matters.

1. Finding your way around PKL

The homepage

The homepage introduces PKL and presents its three main public routes.

Route	Purpose
Browse the ledger	Search and open public knowledge records.
Submit a claim	Propose a new record for review.
Become a reviewer	Read the role, standards and application information.

Using the top navigation

The top navigation provides a direct route to the ledger and a visible Become a reviewer link. On smaller screens, the reviewer link remains prominent while less essential navigation may be condensed.

Back navigation

Internal pages provide a Public Knowledge Ledger or Back to home control. Your browser's Back button may also work, but the on-page control is the clearest route through the current interface.

Direct addresses

You may share the reviewer page directly using /reviewers. Public claim records are opened from the ledger. As stable record URLs are expanded, share the exact record address shown by the site rather than copying text alone.

2. Browsing the ledger

1. Open PKL and choose Browse the ledger.
2. Use the search box to enter a title, subject, claim ID or phrase.
3. Scan the matching cards for the claim title, category, status and statement.
4. Select a card to open the full record.
5. Use the back control to return to the search results.

Searching effectively

- Start with one or two distinctive words rather than a full question.
- Try the subject area if you do not know the title—for example, molecular biology or physics.
- Use a PKL identifier when you have one; this is the most precise search.
- If nothing appears, try a synonym or broader term. No result does not mean the claim is false; it may not yet be recorded.

Seed and reviewed records

The ledger may contain demonstration or seed records as well as submissions that have passed review. Treat every record according to the evidence and review information displayed, not merely because it appears on the website. Future releases should label record origin more explicitly.

3. Reading a PKL record

Read a PKL record as an argument with a history, not as a headline with a badge.

Part	How to interpret it
PKL ID	The stable identity of the claim. Quote this when discussing or reporting it.
Title	A short description; it may simplify the full proposition.
Statement	The exact claim being assessed. This is the most important wording.
Category	The broad knowledge domain used for discovery and reviewer routing.
Status	The current assessment label—not a declaration of permanent truth.
Evidence	Material recorded as supporting or contradicting the statement.
Limitations	Boundaries, uncertainties or missing information needed to interpret the assessment.
Relationships	Other knowledge that supports, contradicts, qualifies or depends on the claim.
Review history	Who made consequential decisions, when and for which reasons, where available.

A good reading order

6. Read the exact statement.
7. Check its scope: who, what, where and when does it cover?
8. Read the status together with its date and stated reasons.
9. Examine evidence quality and origin, not only the number of items.
10. Read limitations and contradictory material.
11. Check relationships and later versions before drawing a conclusion.

4. Understanding statuses

Statuses summarise what the recorded evidence currently warrants under PKL's rules. They can change when the record, evidence or rules change.

Status	Practical meaning
Unassessed	The record has not completed an adequate review.
Uncertain	Evidence is insufficient, weak, closely balanced or materially incomplete.
Supported	The recorded evidence presently supports the claim under the published standard.
Disputed	Material contradiction or unresolved disagreement prevents a single supported conclusion.
Established	Strong, diverse and mature evidence supports the claim, with limitations still recorded.
Superseded	A newer formulation or record has replaced this one without deleting its history.
Withdrawn	The record remains visible but is no longer presented as an active assessment.

What a status does not mean

- It does not mean PKL owns the truth.
- It does not make all supporting evidence equally reliable.
- It does not erase limitations or credible disagreement.
- It does not prevent later correction.
- It does not tell you whether a value judgement is morally right.

If a label seems stronger than the displayed evidence, treat that mismatch as a valid reason to ask for review.

5. Preparing a good claim

A good submission gives reviewers one clear proposition and enough context to examine it.

Before you start

- Search the ledger for the same or a very similar claim.
- Identify the exact proposition you want assessed.
- Collect direct links or citations for the strongest relevant evidence.
- Note serious counter-evidence and limitations yourself.
- Separate factual content from opinion, prediction or recommendation.

Write one assessable statement

Less useful	More useful
Exercise is good.	For most healthy adults, regular moderate physical activity reduces the risk of cardiovascular disease.
This technology is safe.	Under the stated operating conditions, device X met the specified electrical safety standard in test Y.
Everyone knows DNA carries information.	DNA contains biological information used in the inheritance of traits in living organisms.

Check the wording

- One main proposition
- Neutral language
- Relevant population or system
- Time period where it matters
- Definitions for ambiguous terms
- No conclusion stronger than the evidence you cite

6. Completing the submission form

Field	What to enter
Claim title	A short, recognisable name for the record.
Statement	The precise proposition to be reviewed. Required.
Category	The most relevant subject area. Required.
Evidence	One source or evidence item per line. Add enough detail for a reviewer to identify it.
Known limitations	One material boundary, uncertainty or weakness per line.
Related knowledge	One related claim, concept or record per line.

Submitting

12. Open Submit a claim.
13. Complete every required field.
14. Review the wording and evidence entries.
15. Choose Submit for review once.
16. Wait for the confirmation message before closing the page.

A submission does not appear publicly immediately. It enters review and should only become a public ledger record after acceptance.

Evidence entry tips

- Prefer original research, primary documentation or direct datasets where appropriate.
- Include author or organisation, title, date and link when available.
- Do not create or guess a citation.
- Say when evidence is indirect, anecdotal, paywalled or not independently verified.
- Include credible contradictory evidence; doing so strengthens the submission's honesty.

7. What happens after submission

17. Storage — PKL records the proposed claim and assigns submission information.
18. Triage — a moderator checks scope, duplication, minimum information and safe participation.
19. Review — an authorised reviewer examines the statement, evidence, provenance, limitations and conflicts.
20. Decision — the submission may be accepted, returned for improvement, rejected with reasons or escalated.
21. Publication — an accepted submission enters the public ledger with a review trail.
22. Later revision — new evidence or a successful challenge may change the record without deleting its past.

Contributor notification

Direct status notification is a planned capability and may not yet be available for every submission. Until it is confirmed operational, keep any submission identifier or confirmation details and check the ledger or project updates. Do not submit repeated copies solely because a response is not immediate.

Review times

PKL is currently building its reviewer community. Review time will vary by queue size, subject complexity and available expertise. A delay does not imply acceptance or rejection.

8. Corrections, challenges and appeals

PKL is designed to change when the record warrants change. Corrections are part of the system's integrity, not an embarrassment.

Good reasons to raise an issue

- A citation is broken, misquoted or attached to the wrong claim.
- Relevant evidence or a serious limitation is missing.
- Two supposedly independent sources share an origin, dataset, funder or author.
- A status is inconsistent with the displayed reasons or current rule.
- A reviewer has an undeclared material conflict.
- A record contains personal, unlawful or dangerous information that needs urgent handling.
- The interface or API produced an error that prevented participation.

How to report one now

23. Write down the PKL claim ID or submission details.
24. Describe the specific problem and why it matters.
25. Provide the strongest supporting link or evidence you can.
26. State the change you believe is needed.
27. Open a GitHub issue in the PKL repository. Avoid posting private or sensitive information publicly.

A dedicated public correction and appeal workflow is a planned development. Until it is available, GitHub issues provide a transparent project route for non-sensitive matters. Urgent sensitive reports require a protected contact route once PKL publishes one.

9. Becoming a PKL reviewer

28. Open the PKL homepage.
29. Choose Become a reviewer in the navigation or main action area.
30. Read the role, expectations and independence rules.
31. Choose Apply to become a reviewer.
32. Complete the structured application on GitHub, including experience, subject areas, availability and potential conflicts.

Who can apply

Reviewers may bring academic, professional, technical, journalistic or lived-experience expertise. A formal qualification is not mandatory for every role; relevant competence, careful judgement, honesty and willingness to work transparently matter.

Founding-stage status

The current reviewer opportunity is described as voluntary. Any future paid position should be advertised separately and transparently. Applying does not provide immediate access to the moderation console.

Reviewer credentials

Only approved reviewers receive authorised access. Never paste a reviewer token into a public issue, email screenshot, social post or ordinary submission. PKL staff should never need you to publish the token to prove your identity.

10. Privacy, safety and respectful use

Do not submit

- Passwords, API keys, reviewer tokens or authentication details
- Unnecessary personal addresses, telephone numbers or identity documents
- Private medical, employment or legal records without a lawful and appropriate basis
- Material that places a person at credible risk
- Copyright material copied in full when a citation or short permitted extract is sufficient
- Fabricated citations, impersonation, harassment or deliberate manipulation

Public-by-default warning

Treat information submitted for a public knowledge record as potentially publishable. If evidence requires confidential handling, do not place it in the ordinary public form. PKL needs a specific protected process before it can responsibly accept sensitive evidence.

Respectful disagreement

Challenge claims, evidence and reasoning. Do not attack contributors or reviewers as people. A strong correction is specific, sourced, proportionate and open about its own limitations.

11. Troubleshooting

What you see	What it may mean	What to try
Invalid API response	The web page did not receive readable JSON from the API.	Refresh once; check the site address; record the time and action; report it if repeated.
Internal server error	The server failed while handling the request.	Avoid repeated submissions; wait briefly; retry once; report details if it continues.
Submission storage read failed	PKL could not read the configured submission store.	Do not resubmit repeatedly; report the time and page so the storage connection can be checked.
Reviewer authentication required	The private reviewer endpoint did not receive a valid token.	Use only an approved token in the secure console; confirm the environment; never share it publicly.
404 / page not found	The route is missing, stale or not yet deployed.	Return to the homepage; verify spelling; refresh after deployment; report a persistent broken link.
No matching records	The search text does not match a current public record.	Shorten the query, try a synonym or search by category/ID.
Submit button stays busy	The request may still be pending or the network may have stalled.	Wait; do not click repeatedly; refresh only after noting your entries.

A useful technical report

- Exact page address
- Date and time with timezone
- Action you were taking
- Exact error wording
- Browser and device
- Whether refreshing changed the result
- Screenshot with tokens and personal details removed

12. Accessibility and inclusive use

- Use browser zoom or text enlargement as needed.
- Navigate buttons, links and fields by keyboard; report any control that cannot be reached or understood.
- Use field labels rather than placeholder text as your guide.
- Write claims in plain language and define unavoidable technical terms.
- When reporting an accessibility problem, describe the task you could not complete and the assistive technology involved if you are comfortable doing so.

PKL should make complex knowledge inspectable without making participation needlessly difficult. Accessibility problems are integrity problems because they determine who can examine and challenge the record.

13. Frequently asked questions

Does PKL decide what is true?

No. PKL records what the available evidence presently warrants under a visible assessment process. The evidence, reasons, uncertainty and revision history matter more than the label alone.

Can I submit something controversial?

Yes, if it is lawful, assessable, responsibly worded and supported with relevant material. Controversy is not a reason for silent rejection; it may require stronger review and clearer safeguards.

Can one source support a claim?

It can be relevant evidence, but a single source may not justify a strong status. Quality, directness, replication, provenance and conflicts all matter.

Why record limitations?

Because a claim without boundaries is easy to overstate. Limitations help readers understand where the evidence is strong and where caution remains necessary.

Can a published record change?

Yes. Change should occur through a recorded version or event so readers can see what changed and why.

Can I review my own submission?

No reviewer should make an unchecked decision on material where authorship or another interest compromises independence. The relationship should be disclosed and managed through reassignment or additional review.

Is reviewer work paid?

The current founding-stage opportunity is voluntary. PKL may create paid roles later, but these should be advertised with transparent terms and funding safeguards.

Where is the official technical detail?

Use the PKL specification, repository and formal policies for exact system behaviour. The PKL Core Document explains the wider identity and operating philosophy.

14. One-page contributor checklist

Before submitting

- I searched for duplicates.
- My statement contains one main proposition.
- Its scope and important terms are clear.
- My title is shorter than the statement and does not exaggerate it.
- I included my strongest identifiable evidence.
- I looked for contradictory evidence.
- I recorded meaningful limitations.
- I disclosed relevant relationships or conflicts.
- I removed secrets and unnecessary personal information.

After submitting

- I saved the confirmation or submission details.
- I did not submit repeated copies.
- I understand that submission is not publication.
- I am prepared to answer a request for clarification.
- I will provide new evidence or corrections if I discover them.

When reading any PKL record

- Read the exact statement.
- Check the date and scope.
- Inspect evidence quality and provenance.
- Read limitations and contradiction.
- Treat the status as current and revisable.
- Use the claim ID when discussing or challenging the record.

Help guide status

This guide describes PKL’s intended public user journey and identifies important current limitations. It should be revised whenever the website, submission lifecycle, notification system, correction route, reviewer application or support contact changes materially.

Suggested owner: PKL operations or community lead. Suggested review cycle: after each material public release and at least every six months during the founding stage.

For PKL’s identity, principles and full operating model, read the PKL Core Document. For detailed reviewer decisions and conduct, use the future PKL Reviewer Handbook.

Knowledge should be traceable—and the path into the ledger should be understandable.

— Public Knowledge Ledger, User Help Guide v1.0